Voices of the American Indian

By Chrystos and Maurice Kenny

INTRODUCTION

The 2020 murder of George Floyd at the all-too-familiar hand of police brutality has created much needed discussions on the continuing racial disparities in America. But still, Native Americans are left to wonder, will they get left out of this important conversation too?

*The Native American population is small and their voices — not always heard . . . "Who killed George Floyd?" Everything and everyone that contributes to ongoing institutional discrimination. Blacks, Latinos, Native Americans -- the voices rise. Can you . . . **will** you listen?*

The poems "I Walk in the History of My People," by Chrystos and "They Tell Me I am Lost by Maurice Kenny are about pain. The pain that divides the privileged from the suffering, the whole from the broken.

DUCATIONAL

I Walk in the History of My People by Chrystos

There are women locked in my joints

for refusing to speak to the police

My red blood full of those

arrested, in flight, shot

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My tendons stretched brittle with anger

do not look like white roots of peace

In my marrow are hungry faces who live on land the whites don't want

In my marrow women who walk 5 miles every day for water

In my marrow the swollen faces of my people who are not allowed

to hunt

to move

to be

In the scars on my knee you can see the children torn from their families

bludgeoned into government schools

You can see through the pins in my bones that we are prisoners of a long war

My knee is so badly wounded no one will look at it

The pus of the past oozes from every pore

The infection has gone on for at least 300 years

My sacred beliefs have been made pencils, names of cities, gas stations

My knee is wounded so badly that I limp constantly

Anger is my crutch

I hold myself upright with it

My knee is wounded

see

How I Am Still Walking

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Chrystos
Book: This Bridge Called My Back
ISBN: 978-1438454382
Publisher: State University of New York Press
Date (Month/Year): March 2015

They Tell Me I am Lost by Maurice Kenny

my feet are elms, roots in the earth

my heart is the hawk

my thought the arrow that rides

the wind across the valley

my spirit eats with eagles on the mountain crag

and clashes with the thunder

the grass is breath of my flesh

and the deer is the bone of my child

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my toes dance on the drum

in the light of the eyes of the old turtle

my chant is the wind

my chant is the muskrat

my chant is the seed

my chant is the tadpole

my chant is the grandfather

and his many grandchildren

sired in the frost of March

and the summer noon of brown August

my chant is the field that turns with the sun

and feeds the mice

and the bear red berries and honey

my chant is the river

that quenches the thirst of the sun

my chant is the woman who bore me

and my blood and my flesh of tomorrow

my chant is the herb that heals

and the moon that moves the tide

ATIONAL

and the wind that cleans the earth
of old bones singing in the morning dust
my chant is the rabbit, skunk, heron
my chant is the red willow, the clay
and the great pine that bulges the woods
and the axe that fells the birch
and the hand that breaks the corn from the stalk
and waters the squash and catches stars
my chant is a blessing to the trout, beaver
and a blessing to the young pheasant
that warms my winter
my chant is the wolf in the dark
my chant is the crow flying against the sun
my chant is the sun
sleeping on the back of the grass
in marriage
my chant is the sun
while there is sun I cannot be lost
my chant is the quaking of the earth
angry and bold

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although I hide in the thick forest
or the deep pool of a slow river
though I hide in a shack, a prison
though I hide in a word, a law
though I hide in a glass of beer
or high on steel girders over the city
or in the slums of that city
though I hide in a mallard feather
or the petals of the milkwort
or a story told by my father

though there are eyes that do not see me
and ears that do not hear my drum
or hands that do not feel my wind
and tongues which do not taste my blood

I am the shadow on the field
the rain on the rock
the snow on the limb
the footprint on the water
the vetch on the grave

I am the sweat on the boy
the smile on the woman
the paint on the man

I am the singer of songs
and the hunter of fox
I am the glare on the sun
the frost on the fruit
the notch on the cedar
I am the foot on the golden snake
I am the foot on the silver snake
I am the tongue of the wind
and the nourishment of grubs
I am the claw and the hoof and the shell
I am the stalk and the bloom and the pollen
I am the boulder on the rim of the hill
I am the sun and the moon
the light and the dark
I am the shadow on the field

I am the string, the bow and the arrow

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maurice Kenny
Book: Carving Hawk: New & Selected Poems, 1953-2000
Page 109
ISBN: 978-1893996502
Publisher: White Pine Press
Date (Month/Year): 2002

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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